D06 · Network Design & 3PL Management

04 · Cross-border logistics: customs, nearshoring & free trade zones

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1 WHAT IT IS

Cross-border logistics integrates physical movement with trade compliance: tariff classification, rules of origin under the USMCA (T-MEC), programs such as IMMEX, customs brokerage and border crossing operations.

2 WHY IT MATTERS

For supply chains between Mexico and the US, customs is part of lead time and part of cost. **Preferential treatment under the T-MEC is only available when origin is correctly qualified and documented**, and programs such as IMMEX carry real compliance obligations alongside their benefits. Nearshoring business cases that ignore these factors misstate landed cost in both directions.

3 HOW IT IS DONE

1. **Own classification and origin internally.** A controlled tariff classification master and origin qualification per product.
2. **Model landed cost completely.** Duties, brokerage, crossing time, inland freight and inventory effects, by scenario.
3. **Use programs deliberately.** IMMEX and similar programs as strategic assets, with the controls they require.
4. **Audit periodically.** Review classifications, origin claims and broker performance on a fixed schedule.

IN PRACTICE

Integrate trade compliance into product and supplier decisions

Origin and classification consequences should be visible at the time of sourcing and product design, not discovered at the border.

Treat IMMEX and similar programs as strategic assets

They require disciplined compliance but can materially improve the cost position of export manufacturing.

Audit classifications and origin claims periodically

Both under-claiming (leaving money on the table) and over-claiming (creating exposure) are common.

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE

Illustrative case built from typical industry values — not data from a specific company.

Illustrative case — Nearshoring manufacturer moving volume from Asia to Mexico — Initial landed-cost models understated the impact of origin and IMMEX benefits.

Element	Asia Baseline	Mexico with full T-MEC + IMMEX optimization
Unit manufacturing cost	Lower	+8–12%
Duty + brokerage + inland	Higher and variable	Materially lower
In-transit inventory + safety stock	High (30–45 days)	Dramatically lower (1–4 days)
Total landed + inventory cost	Baseline	-9% to -15% depending on product

Result: Once origin qualification, IMMEX and inventory effects were correctly modeled, the nearshoring case became clearly positive for the majority of the portfolio. Several SKUs that looked marginal on pure manufacturing cost became attractive.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

T-MEC / Preferential Origin Utilization %

(Value of imports/exports correctly claiming preferential treatment / Eligible value) × 100

Benchmark: Target close to 100% of genuinely eligible flows

Customs Clearance Cycle Time

Average hours/days from arrival to release

Benchmark: Track by border crossing and mode; chronic outliers indicate process or broker issues

WHAT YOU WOULD USE

Trade & Customs

Trade management systems (Thomson Reuters ONESOURCE, E2open (formerly Amber Road), Descartes, etc.) — Classification, preference management and customs filing support.

Broker systems + internal compliance trackers — Day-to-day execution layer that must be tightly controlled and audited.

4 SO WHAT

Treat customs as a design variable, not paperwork. Own classification and origin, model full landed cost, use programs like IMMEX deliberately and audit before the authority does.

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